

# The New Immigrants

## The Big Idea

Immigration from Europe, Asia, the Caribbean, and Mexico reached a new high in the late 19th and early 20th centuries.

## Why It Matters Now

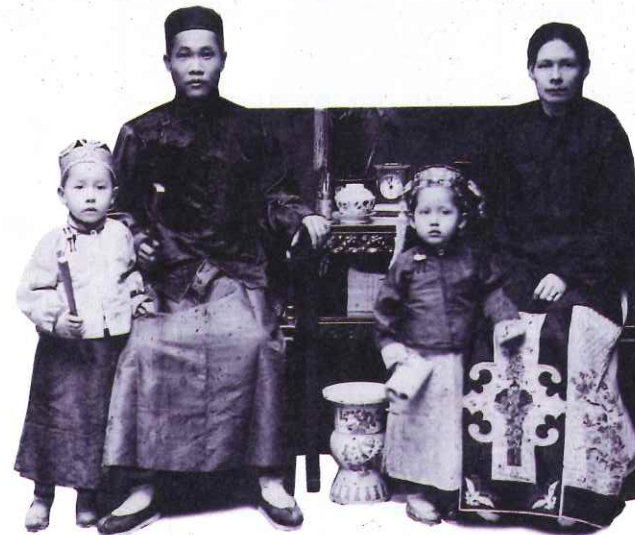
This wave of immigration helped make the United States the diverse society it is today.

## Key Terms and People

Ellis Island  
Angel Island  
melting pot  
nativism  
Chinese Exclusion Act  
Gentlemen's Agreement

## One American's Story

In 1871, 14-year-old Fong See came from China to "Gold Mountain"—the United States. Fong See stayed, worked at menial jobs, and saved enough money to buy a business. Despite widespread restrictions against the Chinese, he became a very successful importer and was able to sponsor many other Chinese who wanted to enter the United States. Fong See had achieved the American Dream. However, as his great-granddaughter Lisa See recalls, he was not satisfied.



*"He had been trying to achieve success ever since he had first set foot on the Gold Mountain. His dream was very 'American.' He wanted to make money, have influence, be respected, have a wife and children who loved him. In 1919 when he traveled to China, he could look at his life and say he had achieved his dream. But once in China, he suddenly saw his life in a different context. In America, was he really rich? Could he live where he wanted? . . . Did Americans care what he thought? . . . The answers played in his head—no, no, no."*

—Lisa See, from *On Gold Mountain*

Despite Fong See's success, he could not, upon his death in 1957, be buried next to his Caucasian wife because California cemeteries were still segregated.

## Background

From 1815 to 1848, a wave of revolutions shook Europe. Most were sparked by a desire for constitutional governments. In 1830, for example, the Polish people rose up against their Russian rulers.

## Through the "Golden Door"

Millions of immigrants, like Fong See, entered the United States in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. They were drawn by pull factors, such as the promise of a better life. Others wanted to escape push factors, such as famine, land shortages, or religious or political persecution. Still others, known as "birds of passage," intended to immigrate temporarily. They wanted to earn money and then return to their homelands.

**EUROPEANS** Between 1870 and 1920, approximately 20 million Europeans arrived in the United States. Before 1890 most immigrants came from countries in western and northern Europe. Beginning in the 1890s, however, increasing numbers came from southern and eastern Europe. In 1907 alone, about a million people arrived from Italy, Austria-Hungary, and Russia.

Why did so many leave their homelands? Many of these new immigrants left to escape religious persecution. Whole villages of Jews were driven out of Russia by pogroms. These were organized attacks often encouraged by local authorities. Other Europeans left because of rising population. Between 1800 and 1900, the population in Europe doubled to nearly 400 million, resulting in a scarcity of land for farming. Farmers competed with laborers for too few industrial jobs. In the United States, jobs were supposedly plentiful. In addition, a spirit of reform and revolt had spread across Europe in the 19th century. Influenced by political movements at home, many young European men and women sought independent lives in America.

## American Literature

### A Poem for Liberty

In 1883 poet Emma Lazarus was asked to write a poem that would be auctioned to raise funds to build a pedestal for the Statue of Liberty. Lazarus was a descendant of Jewish immigrants. She wanted her poem to reflect the hopes, dreams, and fears of immigrants and the promise of a better life offered by the American Dream. The sonnet she wrote, called "The New Colossus," summed up this feeling in these now-famous lines.

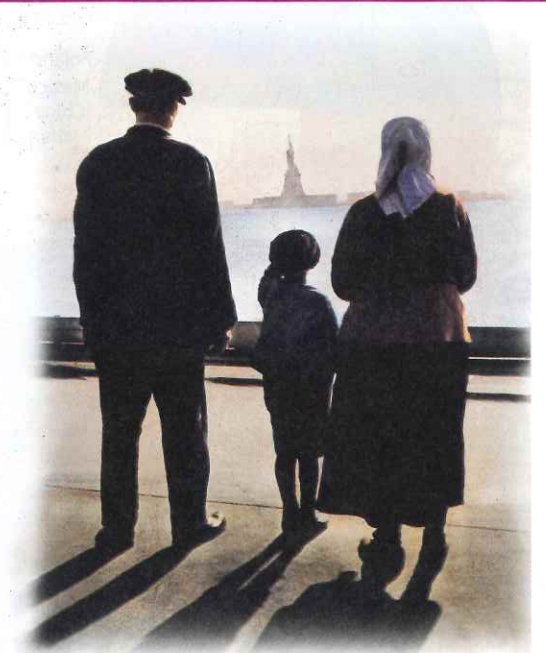
### The New Colossus

"Keep ancient lands, your storied pomp!" cries she  
With silent lips. "Give me your tired, your poor,  
Your huddled masses yearning to breathe free, The  
wretched refuse of your teeming shore. Send these,  
the homeless, tempest-tost to me, I lift my lamp  
beside the golden door!"

—Emma Lazarus, from "The New Colossus"

### Analyze American Literature

What do you think Emma Lazarus is saying about the United States, as compared to other countries at the time?



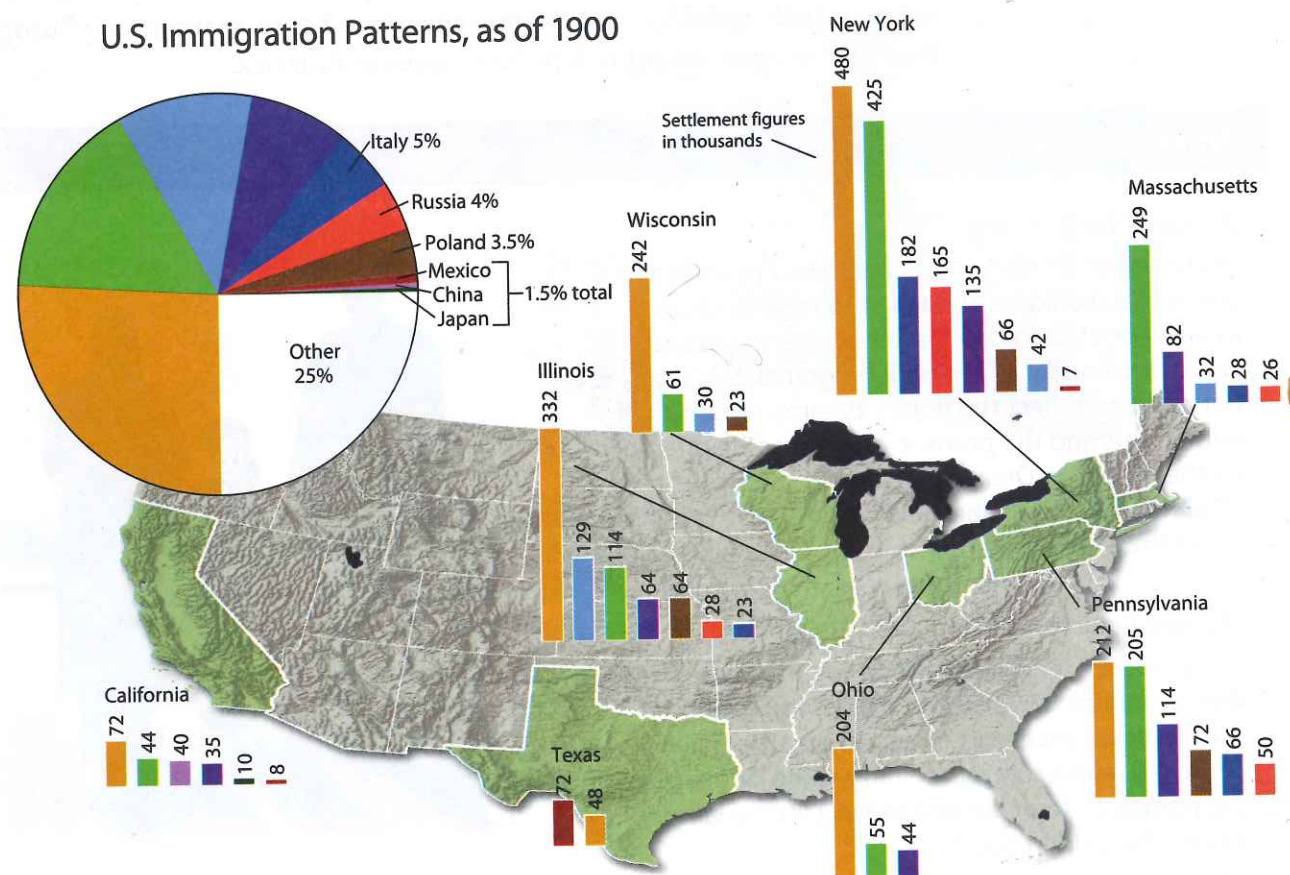


**CHINESE AND JAPANESE** While waves of Europeans arrived on the shores of the East Coast, Chinese immigrants came to the West Coast in smaller numbers. Between 1851 and 1883, about 300,000 Chinese arrived. Many came to seek their fortunes after the discovery of gold in 1848 started the California gold rush. Chinese immigrants helped build the nation's railroads, including the first transcontinental line. When the railroads were completed, they turned to farming, mining, and domestic service. Some, like Fong See, started businesses. However, Chinese immigration was sharply limited by an act of Congress in 1882.

The United States annexed Hawaii in 1898. This resulted in increased Japanese immigration to the West Coast. Immigration continued to increase as word of comparatively high American wages spread. The wave peaked in 1907, when 30,000 left Japan for the United States. By 1920 more than 200,000 Japanese lived on the West Coast.

**THE WEST INDIES AND MEXICO** Between 1880 and 1920, about 260,000 immigrants arrived in the eastern and southeastern United States from the West Indies. They came from Jamaica, Cuba, Puerto Rico, and other islands. Many West Indians left their homelands because jobs were scarce. The industrial boom in the United States seemed to promise work for everyone.

U.S. Immigration Patterns, as of 1900



#### Interpret Maps

- 1. Movement** Where did the greatest number of Italian immigrants settle?
- 2. Movement** From which country did the smallest percentage of immigrants come?

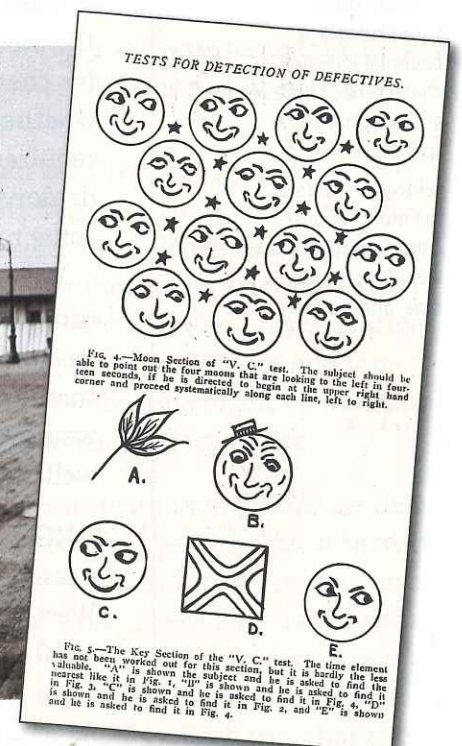
**Reading Check**  
Analyze Causes  
What reasons did people from other parts of the world have for immigrating to the United States?

Mexicans, too, immigrated to the United States to find work and to flee political turmoil. The 1902 National Reclamation Act encouraged the irrigation of arid land and created new farmland in western states. This drew Mexican farm workers northward. After 1910 political and social upheavals in Mexico prompted even more immigration. About 700,000 people—7 percent of the population of Mexico at the time—came to the United States over the next 20 years.

## A Difficult Journey

By the 1870s almost all immigrants traveled by steamship. The trip across the Atlantic Ocean from Europe took approximately one week. The Pacific crossing from Asia took nearly three weeks. Many immigrants traveled in steerage, the cheapest accommodations in a ship's cargo holds. Immigrants were crowded together in the gloom. They were rarely allowed on deck, so they could not exercise or catch a breath of fresh air. They often had to sleep in bunks infested with lice and share toilets with many other passengers. Under these conditions, disease spread quickly. Some immigrants died before they reached their destination. For those who survived, the first glimpse of America could be breathtaking.

**ELLIS ISLAND** After initial moments of excitement, the immigrants faced the anxiety of not knowing whether they would be admitted to the United States. They had to pass inspection at immigration stations, such as the one at Castle Garden in New York City. That station was later moved to **Ellis Island** in New York Harbor. From 1892 to 1924, Ellis Island was the chief immigration station in the United States. An estimated 17 million immigrants passed through its noisy, crowded facilities.



Many immigrants, like these arriving at Ellis Island, were subjected to tests such as the one shown here. To prove their mental competence, they had to identify the four faces looking left in 14 seconds. Can you do it?



## Document-Based Investigation Historical Source

### Immigration

Immigrants faced difficult and sometimes dangerous conditions just to make it to Ellis Island or Angel Island. However, there still was no guarantee that they would be admitted into the United States.

*"America! . . . We were so near it seemed too much to believe. Everyone stood silent—like in prayer. . . . Then we were entering the harbor. The land came so near we could almost reach out and touch it. . . . Everyone was holding their breath. Me too. . . . Some boats had bands playing on their decks and all of them were tooting their horns to us and leaving white trails in the water behind them."*

—Rosa Cavalleri, quoted in *Rosa: The Life of an Italian Immigrant*

*"When I saw Ellis Island, it's a great big place, . . . We all had to gather your bags, and the place was crowded with people and talking, and crying, . . . And we passed through some of the halls there, big open spaces there, and there was bars, and there was people behind these bars, and they were talking different languages, and I was scared to death. I thought I was in jail."*

—Mary Mullins Gordon, from Ellis Island Oral History Project

### Analyze Historical Sources

How was the experience of arriving in the United States different for Rosa Cavalleri and Mary Mullins Gordon?

### Vocabulary

**tuberculosis** a bacterial infection, characterized by fever and coughing, that spreads easily

**felony** any one of the most serious crimes under the law, including murder, rape, and burglary

About 20 percent of the immigrants at Ellis Island were held for a day or more before being inspected. However, only about 2 percent of those were denied entry. The processing of immigrants on Ellis Island was an ordeal that might take five hours or more. First, they had to pass a physical examination by a doctor. Anyone with a serious health problem or a contagious disease, such as tuberculosis, was promptly sent home. Those who passed the medical exam then reported to a government inspector. The inspector checked documents and questioned immigrants. He had to determine whether they met the legal requirements for entering the United States. The requirements included proving they had never been convicted of a felony, demonstrating that they were able to work, and showing that they had some money (at least \$25 after 1909).

Women traveling alone had to remain on the island until a male relative came for them. If they had no male relative in the country, they would often be deported, or sent back to their home country. Under an 1891 rule, inspectors could turn away single women and widows. Officials thought that they would "likely become public charges," or require public assistance, such as welfare.

**ANGEL ISLAND** While European immigrants arriving on the East Coast passed through Ellis Island, Asians—primarily Chinese—arriving on the West Coast gained admission at **Angel Island** in San Francisco Bay. Between 1910 and 1940, about 50,000 Chinese immigrants entered the United States

**Reading Check**  
**Identify Problems**  
What difficulties did immigrants to the United States face?

through Angel Island. Processing at Angel Island was different from the procedure at Ellis Island. Immigrants endured harsh questioning. They were kept in dirty, run-down buildings while they waited to find out whether they would be admitted or rejected.

### Life in the New Land

No matter what part of the globe immigrants came from, they faced many adjustments to a foreign—and often unfriendly—culture.

**COOPERATION FOR SURVIVAL** Once admitted to the country, immigrants faced many challenges. They had to find a place to live and get a job. They had to get along in daily life, while trying to learn an unfamiliar language and culture. Many immigrants tried to find people who shared their cultural values, practiced their religion, and spoke their native language. They settled in ethnic neighborhoods that served as life rafts for immigrants. In these communities, they could speak their native language. In New York City, for example, Jewish immigrants founded a theater that gave performances in Yiddish. This was the language spoken by Jews from central and eastern Europe. They even published newspapers in their own languages.

These ethnic neighborhoods also allowed immigrants to practice their own customs and traditions, which had often been passed down from generation to generation through families. People pooled their money to build churches or synagogues. They formed schools and social clubs to help preserve their customs. Ethnic neighborhoods also provided the comfort foods immigrants craved. These foods included Chinese dumplings, Italian pasta, Jewish latkes, and Polish perogies.

Immigrants also opened local shops and small businesses in these neighborhoods. Established business owners often helped new arrivals by offering credit and giving small loans. Such aid was important for newcomers because there were few commercial banks in immigrant communities.

Immigrants were committed to their own cultures, but they also tried to take on new identities. Many immigrants began to think of themselves as "hyphenated" Americans. They tried hard to fit in. However, these new Polish- and Italian- and Chinese-Americans felt increasing friction as they rubbed shoulders with people born and raised in the United States. Native-born people often disliked the immigrants' unfamiliar customs and languages. Ironically, the descendants of earlier immigrants often viewed these new groups of immigrants as a threat to the American way of life.

**SEEKING OPPORTUNITIES** The majority of European immigrants settled in cities. Most were unskilled workers, so they took low-paying jobs in factories and mills. However, unskilled southern and eastern European immigrants were also recruited to work in the mining industry. These jobs usually paid the same low wages as factory jobs, but they were much more dangerous. Miners worked in dark, cramped conditions under the constant threat of cave-ins. Worse still was the presence of gases, such as methane, that could

**Vocabulary**  
**synagogue** place of meeting for worship and religious instruction in the Jewish faith



This Italian immigrant sells fresh oysters from a cart on the streets of New York City.



**Reading Check**  
Summarize How did immigrants deal with challenges they faced?

**Vocabulary**  
progressive favoring advancement toward better conditions or new ideas

kill if breathed in an enclosed space. On top of that, miners had to deal with pools of stagnant dirty water, coal dust, and swarms of rats. In the early 1900s, mine accidents killed three out of every ten miners in the United States each year.

In 1884 the Japanese government allowed Hawaiian planters to recruit Japanese workers. This caused a boost in Japanese emigration. By 1886 the majority of farm workers in the United States were of Asian descent. These workers included Chinese, Japanese, Indians, and Filipinos. Often they were barred from labor unions because of their race or status as unskilled workers. These immigrants had few protections and suffered terrible working conditions. They usually worked 16 hours a day in the hot sun. Low wages and unsanitary conditions in workers' camps made life for these immigrants even more difficult.

## Immigration Restrictions

Many native-born Americans thought of their country as a **melting pot**, a mixture of people of different cultures and races who blended together by abandoning their native languages and customs. Many new immigrants, however, did not wish to give up their cultural identities. As immigration increased, strong anti-immigrant feelings emerged.

**THE RISE OF NATIVISM** One response to the growth in immigration was **nativism**, or overt favoritism toward native-born Americans. Nativism gave rise to anti-immigrant groups and also led to a growing demand for immigration restrictions.

Many nativists believed that Anglo-Saxons—the Germanic ancestors of the English—were superior to other ethnic groups. These nativists did not object to immigrants from the “right” countries.

Prescott F. Hall, a founder in 1894 of the Immigration Restriction League, identified desirable immigrants as “British, German, and Scandinavian stock, historically free, energetic, progressive.” Nativists thought that problems were caused by immigrants from the “wrong” countries—“Slav, Latin, and Asiatic races, historically down-trodden . . . and stagnant.”

Nativists sometimes objected more to immigrants' religious beliefs than to their ethnic backgrounds. Many native-born Americans were Protestants and thought that Roman Catholic and Jewish immigrants would undermine the democratic institutions established by the country's Protestant founders. The American Protective Association, a nativist group founded in 1887, launched vicious anti-Catholic attacks, and many colleges, businesses, and social clubs refused to admit Jews.

In 1897 Congress, influenced by the Immigration Restriction League, passed a bill requiring a literacy test for immigrants. Those who could not read 40 words in English or their native language would be refused entry. Although President Cleveland vetoed the bill, it was a powerful statement of public sentiment. In 1917 a similar bill would be passed into law in spite of President Woodrow Wilson's veto.



Fear and resentment of Chinese immigrants sometimes resulted in mob attacks, like the one shown here.

**Reading Check**  
Analyze Causes  
How did nativism influence United States' policy on immigration?

**ANTI-ASIAN SENTIMENT** Nativism also found a foothold in the labor movement, particularly in the West, where native-born workers feared that jobs would go to Chinese immigrants, who would accept lower wages. The depression of 1873 intensified anti-Chinese sentiment in California. Work was scarce, and labor groups exerted political pressure on the government to restrict Asian immigration. The founder of the Workingmen's Party, Denis Kearney, headed the anti-Chinese movement in California. He made hundreds of speeches throughout the state, each ending with the message, “The Chinese must go!”

In 1882 Congress essentially slammed the door on Chinese immigration for ten years by passing the **Chinese Exclusion Act**. This act banned entry to all Chinese except students, teachers, merchants, tourists, and government officials. In 1892 Congress extended the law for another ten years. In 1902 Chinese immigration was restricted indefinitely; the law was not repealed until 1943.

**THE GENTLEMEN'S AGREEMENT** The fears that had led to anti-Chinese agitation were extended to Japanese and other Asian people in the early 1900s. In 1906 the local board of education in San Francisco segregated Japanese children by putting them in separate schools. When Japan raised an angry protest at this treatment of its emigrants, President Theodore Roosevelt worked out a deal. Under the **Gentlemen's Agreement** of 1907–1908, Japan's government agreed to limit emigration of unskilled workers to the United States in exchange for the repeal of the San Francisco segregation order.

Although doorways for immigrants had been all but closed to Asians on the West Coast, cities in the East and the Midwest teemed with European immigrants—and with urban opportunities and challenges.

## Lesson 1 Assessment

1. **Organize Information** Create a two-column chart, and list two or more causes of each effect.

| Causes         | Effects                                         |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| 1.<br>2.<br>3. | Immigrants leave their home countries.          |
| 1.<br>2.<br>3. | Immigrants face hardships in the United States. |
| 1.<br>2.<br>3. | Some nativists want to restrict immigration.    |

2. **Key Terms and People** For each key term in the lesson, write a sentence explaining its significance.

3. **Evaluate** What arguments can you make against nativism and anti-immigrant feelings?

**Think About:**

- the personal qualities of immigrants
- the reasons for anti-immigrant feelings
- the contributions of immigrants to the United States

4. **Identify Problems** Which group of immigrants do you think faced the greatest challenges in the United States? Why?

5. **Analyze Effects** What were the effects of the massive influx of immigrants to the United States in the late 1800s?